Photos: MUJEEB FARUQUI





SPRUCING UP
(Top) A resort coming up near Kuno National Park; a road leading to the wildlife reserve undergoing repairs

India. Ecologists all over hope this will mark a turning point in the story of one of most cherished animals, which declined from an estimated global population of 100,000 at the turn of the previous century to 7,100 individuals in 2016-17.

The story has already begun around Kuno. A buzz is in the air. Dinesh has been watching convoys of white official cars, driven at faster-than-usual speeds, perhaps betraying some inner communion with the animal they are hoping to introduce, criss-crossing the bridge on the Kuno for a few days. Captured in Namibia over a month ago, they fly from Windhoek to Jaipur on September 16 in a chartered cargo flight. The final leg for the imported guests, the next day, will be a 40-minute chopper ride to Palpur, an old village site within Kuno where five helipads have been built. Animals suffer during translocation across large distances—they undergo stress, lose weight and get disoriented. That also reduces their fitness for the wild. The month in the *boma*, where carefully arranged prime cuts of small game have been introduced, without competition, should restore some of their spirit. After that looms the free ranging across the great 750 sq. km expanse of Kuno.

So, what are the cons? What risk is entailed here in this grand experiment with nature? What are its ultimate benefits, going beyond the symbolic? These are only some of the big questions that dog everyone invested in the project.

Some of the devil lies in the detail. For the project to succeed even at the elementary level, the cheetahs have to survive—and thrive. That would then lead on to Phase II and III. "Twelve more cheetahs are to come from South Africa. The total number of cheetahs arriving in India will be more than 25. The project will pan out over the next five years," Bhupendra Yadav, the Union minister for environment, forests and climate change, said while reviewing preparations at Palpur on September 11. But very many variables attend on the survival of this slender founder population itself. One is the presence of a sustainable prey base. Cheetahs, because of their slender build, typically go for small game—it would be a dietary shift from the impalas back in Namibia to the chital (spotted deer) and chinkara, but one they can conceivably manage. Traditionally, back in the coursing days, they had to be trained for bigger game—cheetahs would avoid even black bucks in the wild otherwise, for the hunter could end up becoming the aggrieved party. Going for a full-blown nilgai would be a bit of a stretch. With the bigger deer, antelopes and wild boars—part of the buffet that Kuno offers—only calves and mid-sized specimens could therefore become part of breakfast menu, but this is hardly a risk-free venture.

Second, there is the small matter of competition. Resident leopards in Kuno—about 65 in all, or nine per 100 sq. km—and tigers, often known to range in from Ranthambore, just 80-odd miles away, are not likely to be too amused at the new guests at the banquet table. And cheetahs are among the most vulnerable to violence within the big cat pantheon. Predators of different species within a stable ecological niche operate what is known as a guild, tolerating each other, if not exactly cooperating, as long as there's plenty food to go around. The moment the balance shifts, intra-guild competition develops. That's why the action plan envisages radio-collaring Kuno's leopards too, so as to monitor interaction. A lone male leopard—a shorter gentleman, but heavier and fiercer—can chase away cheetahs or, on a bad day, even make a meal of them. Not to speak of striped hyenas, the nasty nether-creatures of myth, which Kuno has no dearth of. Litters of cheetah cubs typically have a 90 per cent mortality rate.

To succeed against these odds, one primarily needs fitness in the founder population—individually robust, and capable of breeding at a healthy replacement rate. A few questions were raised on that front too. Three of the original individuals selected for shipment turned out to be captive-bred—it was only after Indian authorities refused to accept them that they were replaced with free-ranging ones. But definitions have been a bit fluid. The word now is that three of the cheetahs were born wild, but spent some time in enclosures. The gender ratio also stayed a bit grey during the run-up to C-Day. Initially, the first group was said to have four females and four males, which went against conventional translocation wisdom. Always for such experiments, more females are kept in a group. Top sources told INDIA TODAY that the confusion owed to a scarcity of females in the source population. Also, one of the